

“Broken Promises” by Paul Reid

I have never actually written and recorded a song. That was something that always came naturally to my brother who has spent a good deal of his wandering years as a professional musician and has found much success in both performance and album sales. On the other hand, I have never really explored the possibility. When we were given the option of fulfilling the course requirement using any medium we wished, I thought to myself, “I play a little bit of guitar; I should try to write a song.”

“Broken Promises” was recorded on a single track using a downloadable program called Audacity. This program does allow for multi-track recording, however, doing so was well beyond the scope of my expertise. The instrumentation is my own, played with a capo on the 5th fret, on my Art & Lutherie Folk Cedar guitar, with Elixir Phosphor Bronze strings.

Initially, the music was very somber and was at a $\frac{1}{4}$ time signature. As I began to put the lyrics together, it quickly became apparent that this was problematic for two reasons: 1) the slow time really exposed the weaknesses in my musical ability and 2) the song was even more depressing to play and to listen to than I had ever imagined it would be. I changed the tempo to a $\frac{1}{2}$ time signature and changed the chord progression around, to something a bit less dark and a bit catchier.

When I began putting words to music, my original idea was to focus on what it must have been like to have your child sent off to a church run, government mandated residential school. My grandmother Phyllis Stewart was sent off to school at age 6, she was taken from her home community of Gingolx (Kincolith), on the Nass River and sent to a Methodist Indian Residential School called Coqualeetza, in Sardis, BC. Separated from her family for years and by more than a thousand kilometers, her contact with her family sporadic at best, when she returned to the Nass she discovered that much had changed. Her language lost, having endured abuse, upon her return home she found out that while in school her mother, brothers and sisters had all passed away and that her father had remarried. She never really

was able to cope with the pain of that loss and carried that with her for much of her life. In a twist of fate, my father was the architect who designed and oversaw the construction of the Sto:lo Resource Centre on the site of the Coqualeetza Industrial Institute.

It is evident to me that the residential school system is but one of the many examples of the Government of Canada failing the Aboriginal Peoples of Canada. These breaches of their fiduciary duty to Aboriginal Canadians are directly related to the systemic colonization, dislocation, marginalization and incarceration of Aboriginals in Canada.

I thought that it would benefit the substance of the song to try and encapsulate some of the other areas that have led to broken promises and mistreatment of Aboriginal Canadians on the part of the government. The other areas explored are the land grab and creation of the reserve system on the prairies and the continued effort on the part of the government and big business to increase their overall financial capital at the expense of the financial, spiritual, environmental, and cultural wellbeing of Aboriginal groups.

The chorus of "Broken promises" is coupled with the refrain "They are only Indians" and also "We know what's good/right for them". The chorus is designed to echo the claims of Aboriginal people that their rights are being infringed, the first refrain was written to be the response of industry and business as they persuade government to act in their interest and the second refrain is supposed to encapsulate the government's patriarchal notion that they know what is best for Aboriginals and that they are in fact acting in the best interest of the Aboriginals.

I created a slide show to act as a type of music video to accompany the music. I tried to time the visuals so that they changed as the different themes were addressed. Most of the pictures were taken from the Library and Archives of Canada's website. I hope you enjoy listening to the song as much as I enjoyed writing and recording it.

Broken Promises

In the morning,
Just the other day.
White man came around, to survey.
Our ancestral land and all its yields,
To turn it into farmer's fields.

Broken promises.

You fenced us in and built your train,
Murdered the buffalo on the plain.
We are prisoners in our land,
Forced to eat from your hand.

Broken promises.

Broken promises.

(They are only Indians)

Broken promises.

(We know what's good for them)

In the morning,
Just the other day.
The agent came around and you were taken away.

They shipped you off to their school,
Left me feeling like a fool.

Broken promises.

They told me they would treat you,
Like one of their own, but they beat you.
Made to forget your family tree,
Killed our language systematically.

Broken promises.

Broken promises.

(They are only Indians)

Broken promises.

(We know what's right for them)

In the morning,
Just the other day.
The pipeline came and rights were washed away.
They said that they would consult,
The pace of progress cannot halt.

Broken promises.

So many of us are destitute,
Because of the policies they institute.
We are jailed at alarming rates,
They blame us for our impoverished state.

Broken promises.

In the morning,
Just the other day...